

Stories from the heart: On Banu Mushtaq winning the International Booker for Heart Lamp

Banu's Booker will help regional languages gain global **recognition**

The **marginalised** have **come to the fore** with Banu Mushtaq winning the International Booker Prize for 2025. In a first for Kannada, Mushtaq and her translator Deepa Bhashthi walked away with the top **honours** on Tuesday night (May 21, 2025) in London for Heart Lamp. This is also the first time in the history of the prize that a collection of short stories has won. Breaching walls, breaking **ceilings**, and **enduring** angry **outbursts**, Mushtaq **chronicles** the lives of Muslim women and their anxieties. Her stories are also **peopled** by clueless husbands, children who are like “monkeys without tails”, loving and, sometimes **overbearing**, grandmothers, muscular brothers and maulvis. But as Mushtaq has said in interviews, the **narratives** are primarily about women and how “religion, society, and politics demand **unquestioning obedience** from them, and in doing so, **inflict inhumane cruelty** upon them”. She writes with **candour** and **wry** humour, even as the women are often struggling to **stay afloat** with their **backs against the wall**. In her moving acceptance speech, Mushtaq **harped on** the power of words to “create a world where every voice is heard, every story matters, and every person belongs”.

Showering praise on Kannada, she said that it is a language that sings of **resilience** and **nuance** — “to write in Kannada is to **inherit** a **legacy** of cosmic wonder and earthly wisdom”. The 77-year-old Mushtaq **hails** from Hassan in Karnataka, like another **illustrious** writer, Raja Rao, who wrote in Kannada, English and French. **Mushtaq**, a lawyer and **activist**, **was** inspired to write after hearing of the “pain, suffering, and helpless lives” of the women she interacted with. The “**radical** translation” by Bhashthi was praised by the **Jury** chair Max Porter who said it “**ruffles** language to create new textures in a **plurality** of Englishes”. Heart Lamp's **Booker**, just three years after Geetanjali Shree won for Tomb of Sand, **should open doors for** India's rich regional languages to gain a wider readership. Mushtaq follows a **trail** of writers such as Perumal Murugan, Vivek Shanbhag, Bama, Jayant Kaikini, M. Mukundan and S. Hareesh who observe the human condition in a socio-political context with their translators ensuring the **rhythms** of the original language **are** not lost. In a world that often tries to divide people, Mushtaq said that literature remains one of the “last **sacred** spaces where we can live inside each other's minds if only for a few pages”. It is the only place that can **embrace** stories from unheard corners and translations that **defy** borders.

[Practice Exercise]

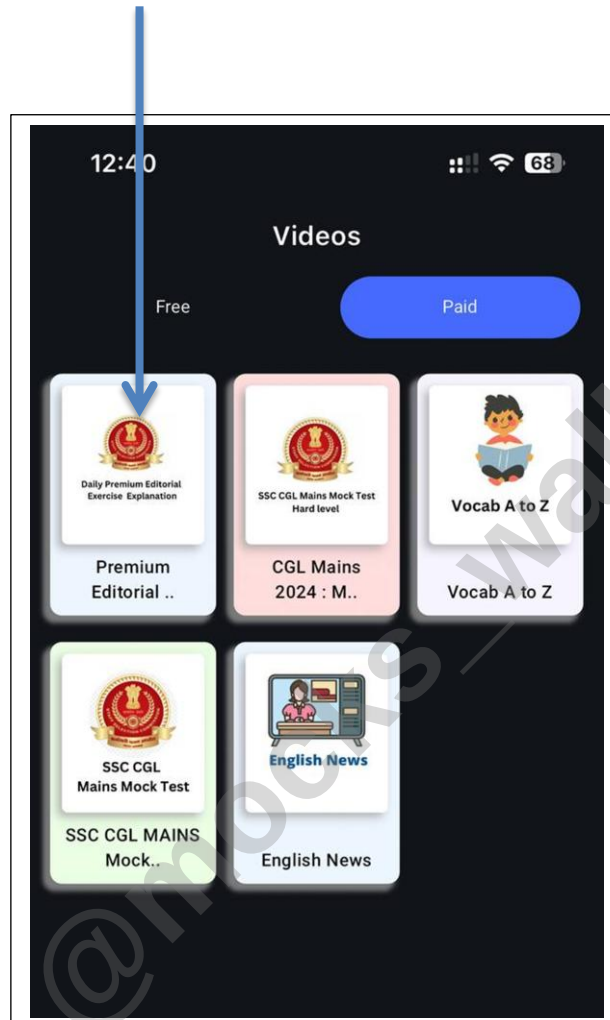
- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.
- People (verb) – (of a group of people) inhabit (a place). रहना/ आबाद करना

Vocabulary

1. **Recognition** (noun) – acknowledgment, appreciation, credit, acclaim, notice
मान्यता
2. **The Marginalised** (noun) – the excluded, the oppressed, the disadvantaged, the neglected, the sidelined हाशिये पर पड़े लोग
3. **Come to the fore** (phrase) – emerge, appear, surface, become visible, gain prominence सामने आना
4. **Honour** (noun) – award, distinction, accolade, recognition, privilege सम्मान
5. **Ceiling** (noun) – limit, cap, upper bound, restriction, maximum सीमा / ऊपरी सीमा
6. **Enduring** (adjective) – lasting, persistent, long-lasting, permanent, abiding स्थायी / सहनशील
7. **Outburst** (noun) – eruption, explosion, flare-up, tantrum, expression उफान / फूट पड़ना
8. **Chronicle** (verb) – record, document, narrate, recount, report क्रमबद्ध रूप से वर्णन करना
9. **Overbearing** (adjective) – domineering, bossy, controlling, oppressive, arrogant हावी होने वाला
10. **Narrative** (noun) – story, account, tale, description, chronicle कहानी / वर्णन
11. **Unquestioning** (adjective) – obedient, accepting, compliant, submissive, loyal बिना सवाल किए मानने वाला
12. **Obedience** (noun) – compliance, submission, conformity, adherence, respect आज्ञाकारिता
13. **Inflict** (verb) – impose, cause, deliver, administer, force upon थोपना / पहुंचाना
14. **Inhumane** (adjective) – cruel, brutal, heartless, ruthless, callous अमानवीय
15. **Cruelty** (noun) – brutality, harshness, savagery, inhumanity, abuse क्रूरता
16. **Candour** (noun) – honesty, openness, frankness, sincerity, truthfulness स्पष्टवादिता
17. **Wry** (adjective) – sarcastic, dry, ironic, mocking, satirical व्यंग्यात्मक
18. **Stay afloat** (phrasal verb) – survive, manage, endure, hold on, get by मुश्किल में भी टिके रहना
19. **Back against the wall** (phrase) – in trouble, in a difficult situation, cornered, pressured, helpless मजबूरी में होना
20. **Harp on** (phrasal verb) – dwell on, emphasize repeatedly, obsess over, reiterate, stress बार-बार जोर देना

21. **Resilience** (noun) – strength, toughness, flexibility, endurance, tenacity मज़बूती
22. **Nuance** (noun) – subtlety, distinction, refinement, delicacy, shade सूक्ष्म अंतर
23. **Inherit** (verb) – receive, acquire, get, obtain, derive विरासत में पाना
24. **Legacy** (noun) – heritage, tradition, inheritance, gift, bequest विरासत
25. **Hail (from)** (verb) – have one's home or origins in (a place). से आना
26. **Illustrious** (adjective) – distinguished, renowned, celebrated, eminent, respected प्रतिष्ठित
27. **Activist** (noun) – campaigner, protester, advocate, reformer, crusader कार्यकर्ता
28. **Radical** (adjective) – revolutionary, extreme, progressive, reformist, groundbreaking क्रांतिकारी
29. **Jury** (noun) – panel, committee, board, adjudicators, judges निर्णायक मंडल
30. **Ruffle** (verb) – disturb, unsettle, disarrange, agitate, disrupt उलझा देना / अस्त-व्यस्त करना
31. **Plurality** (noun) – diversity, multiplicity, variety, range, heterogeneity विविधता
32. **Open the doors for** (phrase) – make possible, enable, allow, facilitate, pave the way रास्ता खोलना
33. **Trail** (noun) – path, route, track, course, line मार्ग / श्रृंखला
34. **Sacred** (adjective) – holy, revered, divine, spiritual, sanctified पवित्र
35. **Embrace** (verb) – accept, welcome, adopt, include, support अपनाना
36. **Defy** (verb) – resist, oppose, withstand, challenge, disobey विरोध करना / अवज्ञा करना

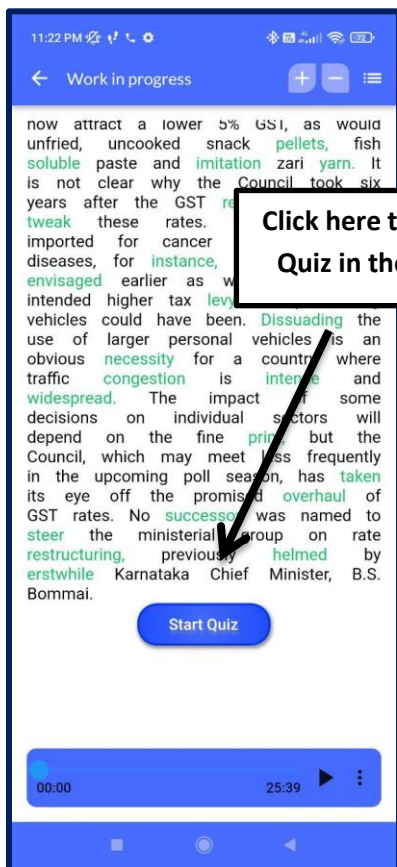
Video solution of Practice Exercise from this Editorial is exclusively available on App.



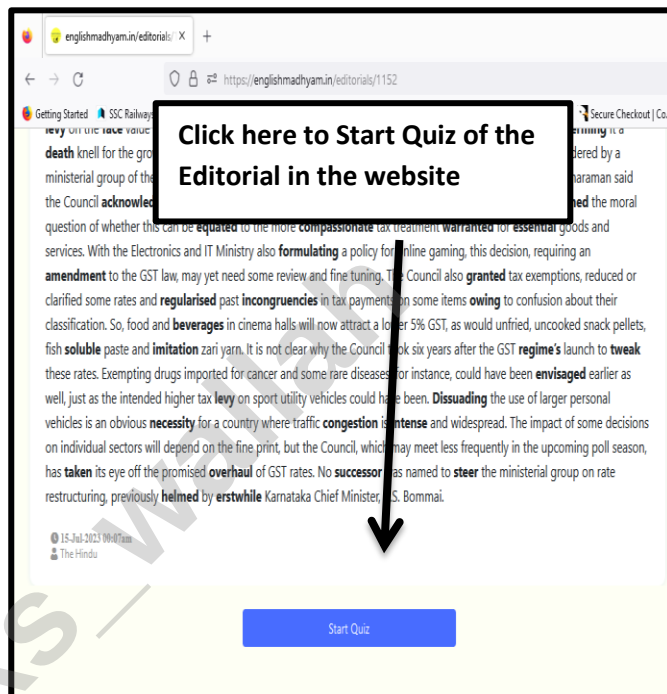
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Historic Win:** Banu Mushtaq became the first Kannada author to win the International Booker Prize (2025), alongside translator Deepa Bhashti, for the short story collection *Heart Lamp*.
2. **First for Short Stories:** It's the first time in the prize's history that a collection of short stories has won the International Booker.
3. **Voices of the Marginalised:** Mushtaq's stories highlight the struggles and resilience of Muslim women, bringing marginalised voices into global literary focus.
4. **Themes and Characters:** Her narratives feature complex women, oblivious husbands, mischievous children, strong grandmothers, and religious figures, portraying layered domestic and societal dynamics.
5. **Critique of Power Structures:** Mushtaq explores how religion, society, and politics impose obedience on women, often leading to their dehumanisation.
6. **Writing Style:** Her work blends candour with dry humour, portraying the desperation and quiet strength of women surviving under pressure.
7. **Acceptance Speech Message:** In her speech, Mushtaq emphasized literature's ability to validate every voice and foster a sense of belonging.
8. **Praise for Kannada:** She called Kannada a language of "resilience and nuance," linking it to a legacy of both cosmic insight and grounded wisdom.
9. **Cultural Roots:** Mushtaq is from Hassan, Karnataka, a region also home to acclaimed multilingual writer Raja Rao.
10. **Activist Background:** A lawyer and activist, Mushtaq was inspired to write by the real-life suffering she witnessed in women's lives.
11. **Celebrated Translation:** Deepa Bhashti's "radical translation" was lauded for its innovation and capacity to convey linguistic texture in multiple English registers.
12. **Impact on Indian Literature:** Following Geetanjali Shree's win in 2022, Mushtaq's success may boost global recognition for India's regional languages and literature.
13. **Literary Legacy:** Mushtaq continues the tradition of Indian regional writers like Perumal Murugan, Bama, and Vivek Shanbhag, who explore human struggles in socio-political settings.
14. **Role of Translators:** Translators are key in preserving the rhythm and soul of regional languages while making them accessible to global audiences.
15. **Power of Literature:** Mushtaq reiterated that literature remains a sacred space where people can connect across divisions, offering a shared emotional and imaginative experience.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



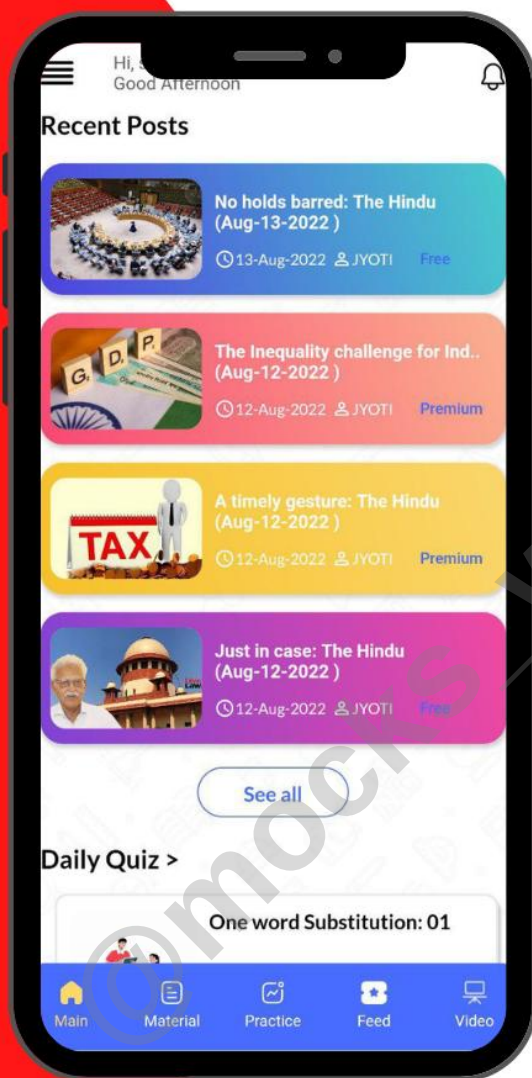
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